Handbook of the La Teulada Verda housing cooperative

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1. Introduction and history

La Teulada Verda is a housing cooperative based on the right of use. This handbook explains how daily life works, how decisions are made and what rights and duties members have. It does not replace the bylaws, but it sums them up in plain words.

The cooperative was founded in 2009. It was started by fourteen families who wanted a way to get decent housing without a lifetime of debt. In the early years they met in a room lent by a neighbourhood association and spent their Saturdays looking for land, talking to architects and working out how to fund the project.

Building work began in 2011 and finished in the spring of 2013. The first families moved in that same summer. Since then the cooperative has grown slowly. Today it has a stable community, with people of all ages and a waiting list of fifty-two families.

The core idea is simple: housing is a right, not a product for speculation. That is why no member owns their flat. Ownership is collective, and each household holds the right of use for as long as it belongs to the cooperative.

2. The right of use model

The land under the buildings is public. The cooperative holds it for seventy-five years in exchange for a yearly fee. When this term ends, the land and the buildings will return to the public administration, which may renew the grant if the cooperative asks for it and has met the conditions.

The site has three buildings with a total of thirty-six homes. There are three sizes: twelve of fifty square metres, eighteen of seventy and six of ninety. Homes are assigned according to household size and, in case of a tie, by seniority on the waiting list.

The right of use has no end date and can be passed on. If a member dies, the right can pass to the person they lived with, as long as that person meets the entry requirements. A home can never be sublet to third parties or used as holiday accommodation.

This model has clear advantages. Fees are lower than market rent, there is no risk of being pushed out by price rises and the community controls its surroundings. It also has demands: members must take part, attend meetings and share collective tasks.

3. Contributions and fees

To join the cooperative you must make an initial contribution of eighteen thousand euros. This is not a purchase price. It is share capital that the cooperative uses to fund itself, and it is paid back, adjusted for inflation, when the member leaves.

Every month, each home pays a usage fee of four hundred and ten euros. The fee covers the construction loan, the land fee, insurance, building maintenance and a reserve fund for the unexpected. Utilities for each flat are paid separately.

The fee is the same for all homes of the same size. Small flats pay twenty per cent less and large ones fifteen per cent more. The general meeting reviews the fees every year together with the budget, and any increase must be backed by figures.

There is a solidarity fund for families going through a hard time. It is fed with one euro from every monthly fee and allows payments to be postponed for up to six months without interest. The finance committee manages it discreetly.

4. The general meeting

The general meeting is the highest decision-making body. All members take part, with one vote per home. It meets twice a year in ordinary session, in March and in October. The March meeting approves the accounts and the October meeting approves the budget for the following year.

A meeting needs a minimum quorum of sixty per cent of the homes to start. If the quorum is not reached at the scheduled time, a second call is made half an hour later, and then the members present are enough.

The cooperative tries to decide by consensus. When that is not possible, a proposal passes if it gets two thirds of the votes cast. Decisions that change the bylaws or sell property also need a yes vote from half plus one of all homes.

The agenda is sent out fifteen days in advance. Any member can add items if they ask at least one week before. The minutes are posted on the notice board in the common room and in the digital archive of the cooperative.

5. Working committees

Daily work is split across five committees: community life, finance, maintenance, surroundings and welcome. Every home must take part in at least one. Committees meet once a month and report on their work at each general meeting.

The finance committee prepares the budget, checks payments and deals with the bank. The maintenance committee organises repairs and keeps the inspection calendar. The surroundings committee looks after the vegetable garden, the green areas and relations with the neighbourhood.

The welcome committee supports new families during their first year. It explains how the cooperative works, introduces them to the neighbours and helps them choose a committee. The community life committee looks after the general mood and steps in when there are conflicts.

Committees may spend up to one thousand five hundred euros without going to the general meeting, always within the approved budget. Above that figure they need explicit approval from the meeting.

6. Shared spaces

A large part of cooperative life happens in the shared spaces. On the ground floor of the first building there is a shared laundry with six washing machines and four dryers. Using these machines is cheaper and takes less space than having one in every flat.

The multipurpose room holds sixty people and has a fitted kitchen. It hosts meetings, dinners, workshops and birthday parties. It must be booked on the shared calendar and left clean after each use.

In the central courtyard there is a vegetable garden of six hundred square metres split into plots. Every home that wants one gets a plot, and there is a common area for herbs and fruit trees. Irrigation water comes from a tank that collects rain from the roofs.

There is also a workshop with tools for small repairs, a covered bicycle park and a guest room that can be booked for up to seven nights in a row.

7. Energy and sustainability

The buildings were designed to use little energy. The walls have thick insulation, the windows are triple glazed and every flat has cross ventilation. In summer, external wooden shutters stop the sun from overheating the rooms.

The roofs carry forty-eight solar panels with a total capacity of nineteen kilowatts. They produce about forty per cent of the electricity the cooperative uses. Surplus energy is shared among the homes and, if there is still some left, it is fed into the grid.

Heating and hot water come from a shared biomass boiler. It burns wood chips from nearby forests and has a filter system to reduce particle emissions. The maintenance committee inspects it every autumn.

The cooperative tracks energy use every year. The data are shared at the March meeting, so each family can compare its use with the average and spot appliances that use too much.

8. Community life and conflict resolution

Living in a community creates conflicts, and that is normal. The cooperative has a protocol to deal with them before they grow. The first step is always to talk directly with the other person, calmly and at a quiet moment.

If talking does not work, either side can ask the community life committee for help. The committee listens to both sides separately and then arranges a mediation meeting. It has a maximum of thirty days to propose a solution.

When mediation does not solve the conflict, the case goes to the general meeting, which can agree on measures. The most serious ones, such as suspending rights or expelling a member, can only be applied for very serious breaches of the bylaws and with a two thirds majority.

There are some basic rules: quiet from ten at night, pets always under control in shared spaces and no personal items in the corridors. The rules are reviewed every two years.

9. Joining and leaving

To join the cooperative you must sign up for the waiting list, attend two information sessions and have an income below the limit set by the public administration. When a home becomes free, the welcome committee contacts the next family on the list.

Before joining, a new family goes through a six month trial period. During that time it takes part in a committee and attends meetings with a voice but no vote. If all goes well, the general meeting confirms its membership.

Anyone who wants to leave the cooperative must give written notice at least three months in advance. During that time they must keep paying the monthly fee. The cooperative pays back the initial contribution within twelve months at most, minus any outstanding debts.

This handbook is updated every time the general meeting approves important changes. If you have questions, ask the welcome committee.